

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Fantasy drama

DIRECTOR

Frank Capra

WRITERS

Frances Goodrich, Albert Hackett, Frank Capra

STARS

James Stewart, Donna Reed, Lionel Barrymore

BEFORE

1934 Frank Capra has his first major hit with the screwball comedy *It Happened One Night*.

1939 In Capra's *Mr. Smith Goes to Washington*, James Stewart plays a naive but honest man who takes a place in the US Senate.

AFTER

1950 In Henry Koster's *Harvey*, Stewart has a big hit playing a likeable man who speaks to an invisible human-sized rabbit.



Ironically, the release of Frank Capra's most enduring motion picture was one of his greatest disappointments. Despite being amply praised by his peers, who appreciated the movie's craft, and winning five Oscar nominations plus a Golden Globe for its director, the movie flopped at the box office. Through the years, however, popular perceptions of the movie changed, and over the course of his life Capra saw it become one of the

George Bailey (James Stewart) woos Mary (Donna Reed), just before tragedy strikes: George's father dies. He has to take over the family business, and never leaves Bedford Falls.

best-loved movies of all time. Today, *It's a Wonderful Life* has become a festive favorite that seems to embody the Christmas spirit.

In the 1930s, Capra had been the voice of Hollywood. He refined the screwball comedy genre with

Minute by minute

